vice-chancellor of the University of Lucknow.

At a time when management education is being redefined—from the relevance of the MBA to the skills required in a changing workplace—Rai, in this conversation with *Business Today*, discusses the future of business education, shifting employer expectations, new learning models, and why conceptual thinking, adaptability and leadership capabilities will remain central to developing tomorrow's leaders. Edited excerpts:

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IIM Calcutta has consistently set benchmarks in management education. What has enabled the institute to maintain this position year after year?

It is a legacy that we have to uphold through consistent and persistent efforts.

The biggest driver at IIM Calcutta has always been keeping students first. Whatever we do at the institute level — whether it is policy decisions, curriculum changes, placements or infrastructure development — the student remains at the centre. Students are the focus of all our initiatives. I believe this has been IIM Calcutta's legacy, and we are trying to carry it forward.

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How closely is the MBA degree keeping pace with the changing nature of work, particularly in the corporate sector?

This is a slightly tricky question because many leading business leaders globally have started questioning the relevance of management education and the MBA degree.

However, I believe any career path has a ceiling, even after postgraduate studies.

For example, engineering education has traditionally been among the most sought-after qualifications. However, engineering graduates increasingly move towards specific skill sets demanded by employers. Yet, when it comes to higher-level decision-making, organisations need more than specialised domain knowledge.

That is what led to the creation of management education, not only in India but across the world.

At the same time, the business environment has changed significantly. One of the biggest challenges we see today is attracting students for a traditional two-year full-time MBA programme.

This will lead to greater growth of one-year management programmes. Some institutions in India already offer one-year management education, beginning with the classic programme introduced by ISB, and now several IIMs have also moved in this direction.

I see this as the next major development in management education.

A one-year programme offers two important benefits. First, it compresses the duration of education from two years to one year. Interestingly, in our executive management programme, while the duration is shorter, the academic intensity remains high.

The second advantage is for professionals who already have work experience. At IIM Calcutta, our MBAEx programme requires a minimum of five years of work experience, but this year the average work experience of the batch was 8.5 years. Professionals benefit because they save one year and gain an additional year of career progression.

I also believe hybrid education will become a major trend. Management education is practice-oriented, and hybrid models allow professionals to continue working while pursuing advanced learning.

"One of the biggest challenges today is attracting students for a full-time two-year MBA programme"

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How are employer expectations changing? Which management skills are becoming more important today?

This question needs to be understood in its entirety. There are different categories of students pursuing management education and different categories of institutions offering these programmes.

When we talk about specific skill sets, they are important, particularly at the entry and mid-level. However, when organisations